

Roots Africa: Social Media Strategy and Information Storytelling

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INST 490: Capstone for Information Science

Professor Andrew Fellows

May 14, 2025

Abstract

Our project focused on helping Roots Africa improve its social media presence, specifically on Instagram. The original goal was to boost general engagement, but after speaking with our main client contact, Cedric, we adjusted the focus to target users aged 35 and older, an audience more likely to donate and support long-term goals. Cedric provided insight into Roots Africa's current strategy, audience behavior, and the importance of building a campaign that feels both authentic and impactful.

We developed a new Instagram feed and caption strategy that centers around storytelling. Our content highlights changemakers, students, farmers, and community members and connects their stories to bigger ideas like sustainability, food security, and education. The images we selected feature real people and unedited moments from rural communities, giving the campaign a photojournalistic honest feel.

Our team also focused on making content accessible and engaging for older users. We followed Instagram best practices by using readable text, clean visuals, and swipe-through carousel posts to tell longer stories. The final strategy includes a full grid mockup, custom captions, and design recommendations that Roots Africa can use moving forward to create consistent, emotionally resonant content that inspires actions.

Methods

We worked through each step of the process, geared toward audience research, content creation, and design planning, aiming to meet the goals of this project and even support the long term social media strategy for Roots Africa. As a first step, we looked into the habits and interests of the people aged thirty-five and above who are our intended group. These are people who are inclined towards content that feels real, informative, and emotionally driven. We got inspiration from studies on social media engagement and similarly sized campaigns to guide us.

Once we had a good idea of the audience, we selected images that truly spoke to the essence of Roots Africa. The photographs chosen showed real people, everyday life in rural communities, farming, nature, and moments of joy and change. These photographs set the tone of the visual feed. Once the visuals were locked in, we proceeded with writing the captions. These captions narrate stories about either a person, an initiative, or an event that are tied into larger narratives of sustainability, food security, or education. We kept the tone clean, emotional, and informative, aiming for the posts to resonate with and inspire the audience.

We also made sure that posts met all the standards of Instagram best practices, especially for older adults. We made simple layouts, readable text, and carousel posts to tell longer stories using the swipe through feature. We basically went for a very strong photojournalistic style of

design with real people, real settings, and hardly any editing on the pictures, so the whole thing felt real yet professional.

Then we made Instagram mockups that showcased how all the posts would flow together, like a feed. These mockups really brought the project to life while giving Roots Africa a clear vision and a concrete understanding of how the strategy would unfold.

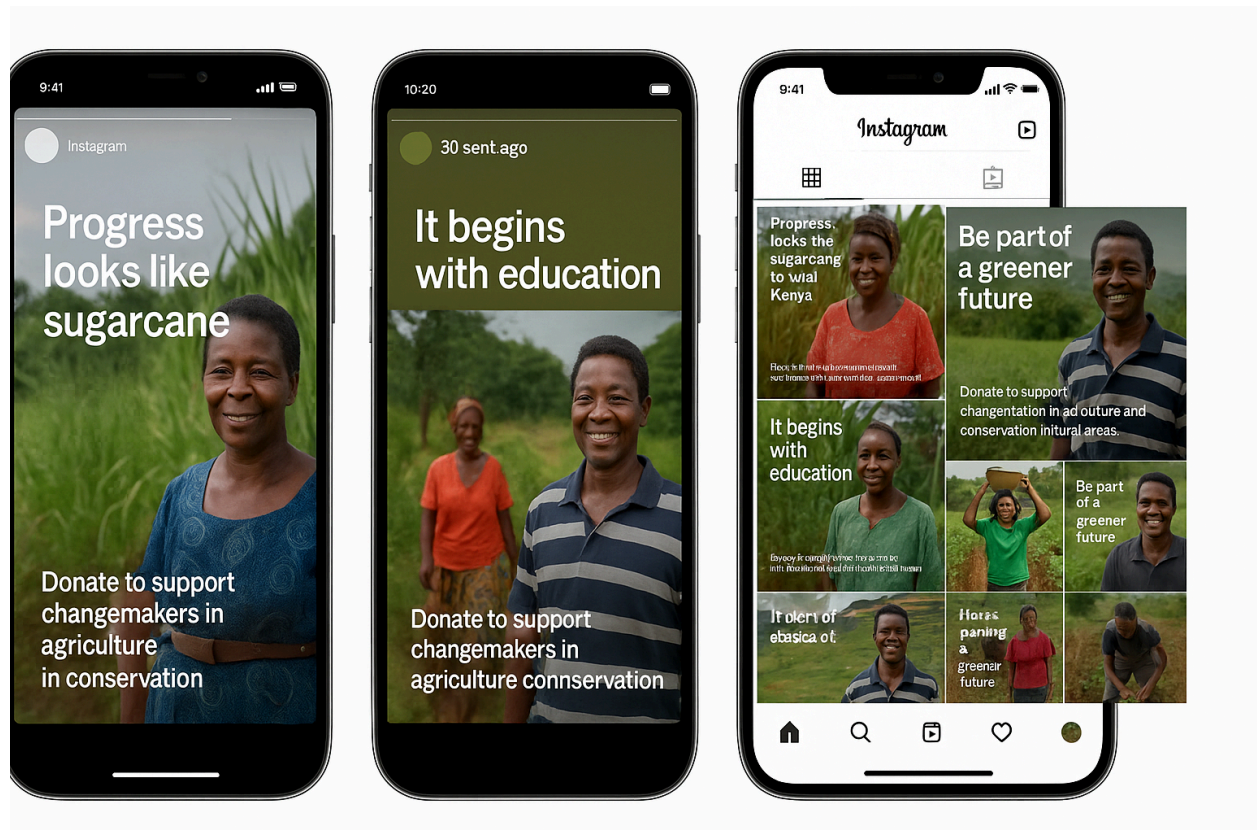
Research

When analyzing their social media platforms we found Roots Africa's has the most engagement from the age range of 25-34 (39.9%). In addition, Leadership/Changemaker-focused content yielded the highest average click-through rate (CTR) of 50%, with strong performance in both impressions and user interactions. Posts highlighting our Changemaker Program and individual changemakers also performed very well, with average CTRs of 37.5% and 36.26%, respectively. Mission- and community-grounded posts, particularly those showcasing fieldwork and relationship-building, maintained a solid average CTR of 32.55%. In contrast, generalized announcements or broad calls to action showed significantly lower engagement, averaging below 7% CTR. Overall, visually engaging reels, especially those with natural landscapes, local culture, and people interaction, consistently outperform static posts. Posts with real people and behind-the-scenes result in higher engagement, highlighting the power of people-centric storytelling. By comparison, generic announcements, agendas, and flyers receive moderate action (20–36 views) but lack visual or emotional resonance to draw more attention. Informational postings are useful but more impactful when paired with strong visuals or narratives framing community benefit. Underperforming content, such as Substack links and graphics-heavy posts, often receives fewer than 20 views, sometimes only one interaction, demonstrating that more dynamic formats and targeting of the audience are required. Static images are not enough by themselves without context or real-world visuals.

Our redesigned Instagram feed is working to engage 35 and above by focusing on authenticity, impact, and trust. Each post features real people, much like farmers, teachers, and community leaders- whose stories reflect profound change. Storytelling using people to which individuals can relate increases the likelihood of donating by up to 80%, according to the Stanford Social Innovation Review. To build trust, we pair the post's captions with credible data. This appeals to older donors, whom the Charitable Giving Institute reports are twice as likely to give when they are shown measurable results. Our photos communicate values of family, work ethic, and leadership that allow followers to imagine themselves in the stories. Clear, polite calls to action, i.e. "Tap the link in bio to support our mission", aligned with research showing that older audiences engage best with direct, focused messaging. This works by coupling emotional storytelling with data-driven impact, building connection alongside credibility.

Deliverables

1. Curated Instagram Feed:
 - Unified grid with local life, wildlife, landscape, farming, and community-led projects.
2. Caption Set (Changemaker Focus):
 - Each image is accompanied by a corresponding caption highlighting a person, initiative, or transformation, often referring to local scope or global scholarship on development (i.e., food sovereignty, microfinance, or eco-stewardship).
3. Instagram/Facebook/LinkedIn Post Mockups (see attached images below):
 - High-fidelity visual mockups available to describe final output and tone.
4. Design Rationale:
 - The grid structure and caption tone were chosen after research showed that users 35+ are more likely to react to posts that: authenticity, informed giving, and emotional engagement.
5. Posting Schedule to Engage Liberia, Uganda, USA, etc.:
 - 12 PM Eastern Time, Tuesday-Thursday.



Empowering farmers is key to building a brighter future. Let's support the next generation of agricultural leaders across Africa!

[#agriculture](#) [#farming](#) [#youth](#)



Recommendations

Based on our social media strategy and performance analysis, we recommend that Roots Africa continue investing in narrative-driven content—particularly content that highlights changemakers and the community impact of their work. These posts consistently generated the highest engagement rates across both Instagram and LinkedIn. Our mock-ups and captions that focused on personal stories and on-the-ground action demonstrated clear audience interest in authentic, mission-aligned storytelling.

To build on this success, we suggest the following next steps:

1. Implement Instagram Reels and short-form video content: Short, engaging videos featuring student changemakers, behind-the-scenes work in the field, or quick progress updates can dramatically increase reach and retention.
2. Create a content calendar that includes weekly features like “Changemaker Spotlights” or “Community Voices” to establish a consistent, recognizable posting rhythm.
3. Incorporate data-driven storytelling using basic visualizations or infographics on impact metrics (e.g., number of students trained, farms supported, partnerships formed).

4. Use Instagram Stories and interactive elements (polls, Q&A, quizzes) to increase two-way engagement and gather organic feedback from followers.
5. Develop a branded hashtag strategy (e.g., #RootsInAction, #ChangemakersOfRoots, #PlantingOurRoots) to build community recognition and track campaign performance.

Conclusion

Our strategy and research establishes the groundwork for Roots Africa to continue to improve their social media and reach an older audience. If the organization maintains this new strategy and works with teams in the future to improve upon it with real-time data research/feedback, we expect that they will be able to successfully increase donor engagement and get more support for the communities they work with. The research we conducted found that audiences of over 35 are more likely to respond to stories and data. Using this feedback, we were able to create mockups of social media posts including graphics and captions.

Future steps for the client include: implementation of social media and data tracking, long-term (1-3 months) tracking of before and after social media changes, and reevaluation of graphics, captions, posting frequency, and other elements of the social media strategy. Once all of this information has been collected, the organization should implement changes and restart the evaluation process. It is important to remember that strategizing never ends, and because of the content medium, it will need to be reevaluated at least once a year. Social media trends frequently change, and so the strategy will need to be adapted likewise.

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